

THE SECRET NUKE SUB DEAL

How a stealthy agreement with Russia gives India an undersea platform to launch nuclear weapons

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

On June 15, 2008, the Indian Navy will commission the *INS Chakra*, a 12,000-tonne Akula-II class nuclear-powered attack submarine, from the far eastern Russian port of Vladivostok. The submarine, which is being built at a shipyard in Komsomolsk-on-Amur, marks the fruition of a \$650-million (Rs 2,600 crore) secret deal signed by the NDA government three-and-a-half years ago, which said that India would finance the construction of an unfinished Russian nuclear submarine hull and then lease it for 10 years. The impending acquisition of the *Chakra* gives India the long-awaited third leg of the nuclear triad—the others being air and land-based nuclear delivery platforms—widely regarded as the most survivable mode of launching nuclear weapons.

"It is the most crucial strategic capability we are acquiring after testing nuclear weapons in 1998," says strategic analyst Bharat Karnad. Manned by a specially trained Indian crew, the *Chakra*—named after Krishna's weapon—will undertake a 15-day pas-

sage through the South China Sea, with no port calls, to India, where it will be formally inducted as a component of India's strategic forces command.

Nuclear submarines use a miniature nuclear reactor, to produce steam, which drives a turbine. Capable of tremendous underwater speed and almost unlimited endurance, they are in fact limited only by the endurance of their crew. The Akula-II submarine's speed of 35 knots and diving depth of 600 m is twice that of a conventionally powered submarine. "However, a nuclear submarine is much more than just a submarine with a nuclear reactor," says Rear Admiral (retired) Raja Menon. "It is the arbiter of power at sea," he adds.

Armed with indigenously built nuclear-tipped cruise missiles with a range of over 1,000 km, the *Chakra* will be a potent addition to India's strategic arsenal. A need which was felt after the Pokhran tests of 1998 when India enunciated a nuclear doctrine of 'no first use' and nuclear forces based on a triad of aircraft, mobile land-based missiles and sea-based assets, to ensure that its nuclear deterrent was "effective, enduring, diverse, flexible, and responsive to the requirements of credible minimum deterrence". While the road and rail-mobile Agni

series missiles afforded the land-based legs of the triad, the focus quickly shifted on inducting submarines armed with nuclear weapons. India's Advanced Technology Vessel (ATV), a euphemism for a nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine (SSBN) project initiated in the 1970s was still a decade from induction.

Hence talks on leasing two Akula class submarines—later reduced to one—were begun by the Vajpayee government after the Kargil War in 1999. Code-named Project (I), it was part of the three key naval items on the list of the Indian-Russian Inter-Governmental Commission on Military Technical Cooperation initiated by the government in 2002. The other two items on the list were the purchase of the *Admiral Gorshkov* aircraft carrier, and the lease of four Tu-22M strategic bombers (which has since been cancelled). Funds for the submarine lease were allotted by the Central Government, but never publicised. The deal for leasing the submarine was signed quietly in Delhi in January 2004 along with the *Gorshkov* deal, during Russian Defence Minister Sergei Ivanov's visit.

Yet for years, the government denied plans of leasing nuclear submarines. Ivanov, too, consistently

STEEL SHARK: A Russian Navy Akula class submarine in the Pacific

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